

Request for CJK Review of an Additional Contextual Abbreviation/Omission Use of U+303B ㄱ VERTICAL IDEOGRAPHIC ITERATION MARK

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Draft for Unicode Technical Committee / CJK & Unihan Working Group review
No L2 document number has been assigned.

Item	Submission position
Submission-purpose category	Change to glyphs, properties or other information for an existing character or characters (including symbols)
Character concerned	U+303B ㄱ VERTICAL IDEOGRAPHIC ITERATION MARK
New characters requested	None
New code points requested	None
Unicode character-name change requested	None
Normative UCD property change requested	None at this stage
Representative glyph replacement requested	No
Primary request	CJK technical review of an additional contextual abbreviation/omission use; guidance on whether and when informative documentation would be appropriate
Requested routing	CJK & Unihan Working Group / Unicode Technical Committee

Submission status and scope

This document is intentionally narrower than a proposal to encode a new abbreviation symbol. It asks Unicode CJK experts to review whether the already encoded character U+303B can serve, in a language-specific or higher-level convention, as a contextual marker that a preceding Han-character expression has been intentionally shortened. The proposed hooked/cursive form shown below is submitted only as an illustrative handwritten or typographic variant of U+303B, not as a separate abstract character and not as a requested replacement for the Unicode code-chart glyph.

The immediate requested outcome is technical guidance and, if the working group considers it appropriate and sufficiently evidenced, a path toward future informative documentation. The proposal does not ask Unicode to prescribe Chinese abbreviation policy, require the convention, or standardize the abbreviations themselves.

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1. Executive summary

U+303B 𐤎 VERTICAL IDEOGRAPHIC ITERATION MARK is already encoded in the CJK Symbols and Punctuation block. The Unicode NamesList currently identifies it as “VERTICAL IDEOGRAPHIC ITERATION MARK.” [1] A separately encoded historical mark, U+16FE3 OLD CHINESE ITERATION MARK, is cross-referenced by Unicode to both U+3005 IDEOGRAPHIC ITERATION MARK and U+303B. [2][3]

The submitter proposes to test an additional contextual use of U+303B after a shortened Han-character expression. In that use, the mark would signal that the preceding expression is intentionally abbreviated and that omitted linguistic material is recoverable from context. The conceptual reading is approximately: “the preceding expression is shortened; expand from context.”

The submission does not seek a new code point, new character name, canonical equivalence, variation sequence, normalization mapping, or duplicate representation. It also does not ask the UTC to change the fundamental identity of U+303B, which would be constrained by the Unicode Character Encoding Stability Policies. [4]

Because the convention is not yet an established orthographic standard with broad independent usage, the document is framed as a request for CJK review and encoding guidance. A later request for an informative NamesList or Core Specification note should be contingent on stronger usage evidence and language-community or standards-body support.

2. Exact request to Unicode

The submitter respectfully requests that the CJK & Unihan Working Group consider the following questions and provide a recommendation to the Unicode Technical Committee where appropriate:

1. Whether U+303B is the appropriate existing Unicode character for experiments or standards that use the mark after a shortened Han-character expression to indicate contextual omission/abbreviation.
2. Whether the submitter-supplied hooked/cursive form can reasonably be treated as a glyphic or calligraphic realization of U+303B, rather than a distinct character requiring separate encoding.
3. Whether any Unicode data-property change is necessary for such a higher-level use. The submitter's current position is that no normative UCD property change is needed.
4. What evidence threshold would be appropriate before Unicode considers an informative NamesList annotation or explanatory Core Specification text acknowledging an abbreviation/omission use.
5. Whether the orthographic convention itself should principally be developed by relevant language, terminology, publishing, or national standards bodies, while Unicode provides only the interoperable character encoding.

No request is made to rename U+303B. Unicode's name-stability policy states that the Unicode Name value of an encoded character does not change; inaccuracies or broadened understanding are handled through annotations or descriptive text rather than renaming. [4]

3. Current identity of U+303B and stability constraints

The proposal treats the existing abstract character as fixed. The requested discussion concerns additional contextual use and possibly informative documentation, not re-identification of the code point.

Property / characteristic	Current or proposed treatment
Code point	U+303B
Unicode name	VERTICAL IDEOGRAPHIC ITERATION MARK
Block	CJK Symbols and Punctuation
General Category	Lm (Modifier Letter)
East Asian Width	W (Wide)
Line Break	NS (Nonstarter)
Vertical Orientation	U (Upright)
Normalization/decomposition	No new mapping requested
Bidirectional behavior	No change requested

The General Category and East Asian Width values are consistent with current Unicode data for U+303B, while Unicode line-breaking documentation lists U+303B among NS (Nonstarter) characters. [5][6] The proposed abbreviation use does not require changing these behaviors.

The Unicode Character Encoding Stability Policies expressly permit some property or representative-glyph corrections over time, but not changes that alter a character's fundamental identity. [4] This proposal is designed to remain within that constraint.

4. Proposed contextual abbreviation/omission convention

Proposed abstract pattern:

SHORTENED HAN EXPRESSION + U+303B

The presence of U+303B would indicate that the preceding Han-character sequence is intentionally incomplete relative to a fuller lexical or terminological expression. The convention would be optional and context-sensitive. It is intended especially for very short abbreviations that might otherwise be mistaken for ordinary words or for strings whose abbreviated status is not visually obvious.

Illustrative constructed examples (not evidence of established community usage):

Full expression	Illustrative shortened form	Comment
人工智能	智 ㄣ	artificial intelligence; one-character contextual abbreviation
客户关系管理	客关管 ㄣ	customer relationship management
中央处理器	央处器 ㄣ	central processing unit
邮政特快专递	邮快 ㄣ	express mail service
净变现价值	净现价 ㄣ	net realizable value
暖通空调	暖通空 ㄣ	heating, ventilation, and air conditioning

The exact abbreviation-formation rules are outside Unicode's scope. Regional standards bodies, publishers, terminologists, language communities, or scholarly conventions would determine when the mark is appropriate, how the shortened form is derived, and whether multiple consecutive marks have any specialized meaning. Unicode's role would be limited to encoding and documenting the existing character.

5. Illustrative glyph and character-versus-glyph analysis

The image below is a cleaned rendering derived from the submitter-supplied concept image. It is intended to show a possible handwritten/calligraphic style of U+303B. It is not proposed as a new character, a standardized variation sequence, or a mandatory representative glyph.



Figure 1. Submitter-supplied hooked/cursive glyph concept for U+303B. Non-normative illustration; no separate encoding requested.

Unicode proposal guidance emphasizes the distinction between characters and glyphs and notes that minor written variants are generally not separate Unicode characters. [7] The present proposal therefore makes the abstract-character identity explicit: the intended encoded text remains U+303B regardless of the font or handwritten form used to display it.

No font file is included with this draft because no code-chart representative-glyph replacement is requested. If a later stage requests a representative glyph change or requires a font contribution, the Unicode Font Submission Policy and licensing requirements would apply. [8]

6. Historical and functional background

The historical argument is deliberately framed as functional context rather than proof that a modern abbreviation use already exists. Medieval and earlier Chinese manuscript traditions contain scribal notation for repetition, ligature/joint graphs, correction, omission, and other forms of information compression. Imre Galambos' s research is particularly relevant because it documents the hewen (ligature) and chongwen (duplication) marks in Chinese manuscript practice and stresses that the same small double-dash notation could be interpreted differently according to context. [9]

Galambos also cautions against over-identifying such notation with a particular modern character and notes that some ligature practices were graphical rather than necessarily phonetic abbreviations. [9] That caution is adopted here. The proposal does not claim that every historical repetition or ligature mark was an abbreviation mark in the modern sense.

His broader study of punctuation in medieval Chinese manuscripts likewise demonstrates that scribal marks were diverse, often tied closely to manuscript practice, and not always preserved in transmitted editions. [10] This supports a cautious historical proposition: East Asian writing has longstanding mechanisms by which small auxiliary marks can modify how adjacent written material is interpreted, including repetition, omission, or grouping. It does not by itself establish a modern orthographic standard.

The submitter' s hypothesis is therefore modest: the existing U+303B belongs to a historically related functional domain of iteration and non-rewriting, and that functional proximity makes it a plausible candidate for a modern, optional omission/abbreviation convention if language communities choose to adopt one.

7. Relationship to U+16FE3 and other encoded marks

Unicode separately encodes U+16FE3 OLD CHINESE ITERATION MARK in the Ideographic Symbols and Punctuation block. The Unicode NamesList cross-references U+16FE3 to U+3005 IDEOGRAPHIC ITERATION MARK and U+303B VERTICAL IDEOGRAPHIC ITERATION MARK. [2] The original encoding proposal, WG2 N4847 / L2/17-310 by Andrew West and Eiso Chan, treats the old mark as a distinct character despite functional similarity to the modern iteration marks. [3]

Accordingly, this document does not assert that U+16FE3 and U+303B are the same character, nor that U+303B descends directly from the old equals-sign-shaped form. It uses N4847 only as evidence that Unicode itself recognizes a functional relationship among distinct Chinese iteration marks and that historical glyphic form must be distinguished from abstract-character identity.

U+3005 IDEOGRAPHIC ITERATION MARK is also relevant as a modern iteration mark, but the present proposal focuses on U+303B because the submitter's intended handwritten/calligraphic form and placement conventions are closer to the desired visual behavior. No claim is made that U+303B is the only possible character a language community could choose for such a convention.

8. Plain-text encoding and implementation behavior

The principal technical advantage of reusing U+303B is that the convention requires no new plain-text representation. For example:

智彡 = U+667A CJK UNIFIED IDEOGRAPH-667A + U+303B VERTICAL IDEOGRAPHIC ITERATION MARK

Existing software can store, transmit, search, copy, and normalize the sequence using already encoded characters. The proposal does not introduce a new decomposition, compatibility mapping, combining class, variation selector, or private-use dependency.

Line breaking. Unicode line-breaking documentation classifies U+303B as NS (Nonstarter). [6] That behavior is compatible with a suffix-like contextual mark, because it ordinarily should not begin a line independently of the preceding expression. No line-break change is requested.

Width and vertical layout. U+303B is East Asian Width W and is treated upright in Unicode vertical-orientation data. [5] The proposed usage is intended to remain compatible with both horizontal and vertical CJK text. No automatic rotation or contextual glyph substitution is requested by this proposal.

Search and collation. A language-specific application may choose whether searches for the full term and the marked abbreviation are linked, but that is a higher-level protocol issue. The Unicode Collation Algorithm need not be changed merely because a community assigns an additional orthographic meaning to U+303B.

Identifiers and syntax. The proposal does not request that U+303B be made an identifier character, nor that its Pattern_Syntax or other identifier-related properties change. Specialized

programming-language or metadata use, if any, would require separate higher-level specifications.

9. Evidence status, scope, and standardization boundary

Unicode character-encoding proposals ordinarily require evidence of usage, stability, and interchange need for new characters. [7] This submission differs because it does not request a new character. Nevertheless, the same evidentiary discipline is useful when asking Unicode to document a new usage of an existing character.

Current evidence status:

- The abstract character U+303B is already encoded and interoperable.
- The historical record establishes related Chinese scribal practices involving repetition, ligature, and contextual interpretation, but does not by itself prove the proposed modern abbreviation convention.
- The example abbreviations in this document are constructed by the submitter for testing and illustration; they are not presented as evidence of independent established usage.
- The proposal is therefore best treated initially as a request for encoding guidance and expert review, with future documentation contingent on independent use, corpus evidence, scholarly support, and/or standards-body adoption.

This scope limitation is intentional. It avoids asking Unicode to create a normative linguistic policy. A Chinese, Japanese, Korean, Vietnamese, or other CJK-associated standards body could develop an orthographic convention independently while still using U+303B as the underlying encoded character.

10. Requested CJK & Unihan review questions

1. Does the proposed contextual abbreviation/omission meaning remain compatible with the fundamental identity of U+303B under Unicode stability policy?
2. Would Unicode consider the hooked/cursive figure a permissible glyphic realization of U+303B, assuming it remains recognizably related to the encoded character, or should the proposal avoid any glyph claim beyond “illustrative handwriting style” ?
3. Is any UCD property change needed? The submitter recommends none.
4. Would an eventual NamesList annotation be the most appropriate Unicode documentation mechanism, or would Core Specification text, a Unicode Technical Note, or no Unicode documentation be preferable?
5. What independent usage or corpus evidence would the working group want before supporting an informative annotation?
6. Would the working group recommend consultation with national or regional language/terminology standards bodies before any further Unicode action?
7. Is there any existing CJK punctuation or iteration-mark precedent that the submitter should study before revising the proposal?

11. Intellectual-property and rights-holder register

Unicode requires proposal authors and potential IP holders to be identified and requires compliance with its Intellectual Property, Licensing & Technical Contribution Policies; CJK & Unihan submissions are also subject to CLA requirements. [11][12] The following register is provided so that rights issues are explicit before submission.

Material	Potential rightsholder / claimant	Use in this draft	Submission action
Proposal text and original analysis	Scottilynn Blank	Original contribution by submitter	Submitter should sign/confirm an applicable Unicode CLA.
Figure 1: hooked/cursive U+303B concept	Submitter-supplied image; Scottilynn Blank should confirm provenance and authority to license	Included as a non-normative illustration	Before filing, confirm that the image is original to the submitter or otherwise lawfully licensable; identify any other claimant if applicable.
Unicode character names, data, policies, and web documentation	Unicode, Inc.	Cited and paraphrased only; no Unicode chart screenshot reproduced	No separate permission ordinarily needed for citation; follow Unicode Terms of Use for any reproduced material.
WG2 N4847 / L2/17-310	Andrew West and Eiso Chan; document distributed through WG2/Unicode	Cited and paraphrased only; no figure copied	No separate figure permission sought because no image is reproduced.
“Punctuation Marks in Medieval Chinese Manuscripts” (2014)	Imre Galambos (author); De Gruyter Brill is the publisher/rightsholder for the published chapter	Cited and paraphrased only	Do not reproduce publisher figures/pages without permission; citation alone is used here.
“Scribal Notation in Medieval Chinese Manuscripts” (2010)	Imre Galambos (author); Research Group / Centre for the Study of Manuscript Cultures, University of Hamburg, as publisher/host	Cited and paraphrased only	No manuscript photograph or page facsimile reproduced in this proposal.
Any manuscript photographs added in a future revision	Potentially the holding institution, photographer, digitization project, publisher, and/or other rights holder	Not included	Clear rights or public-domain status for each specific image before submission.

This register is a practical submission checklist, not a legal opinion. The Unicode submission form should list all authors and any person or entity that may claim IP rights in contributed glyph artwork or other proposal material. If a font is later contributed, the Unicode Font Submission Policy applies separately. [8][11]

12. Scholarly consultation and Imre Galambos

Professor Imre Galambos (University of Cambridge) is a particularly relevant scholar to consult because his research addresses Chinese manuscript culture, Dunhuang, the history of Chinese writing, punctuation, ligatures, and duplication marks. His published work is cited in this proposal. [9][10][13]

Consultation status: the submitter intends to invite Professor Galambos to comment on the historical analysis and on whether the proposed relationship among repetition, omission, ligature, and modern abbreviation has been framed accurately. He is not listed as an author, co-proposer, endorser, rights holder of the submitter's glyph, or representative of Unicode. Citation of his research does not imply endorsement.

If Professor Galambos chooses to make substantive authored contributions to the proposal text, the Unicode submission should then identify him as an author and address the applicable CLA requirement. If he merely provides informal scholarly feedback or a separate endorsement, that status should be described accurately rather than converting him into a co-author without consent.

13. Submission-format compliance checklist

This draft is formatted to follow the Unicode document-submission rules of thumb and the proposal requirements relevant to existing-character changes. [7][12] Before submission, verify each item below:

- ☐ Single PDF document.
- ☐ Title, author, and date shown on the first page.
- ☐ Headers/footers and page numbers included.
- ☐ No self-assigned L2/yy-*nnn* document number template.
- ☐ All fonts embedded in the PDF.
- ☐ PDF is not password-protected and does not inhibit viewing, printing, annotation, or text extraction.
- ☐ File size remains within Unicode submission limits or is supplied by an accepted URL/upload method.
- ☐ Purpose category selected as “Change to glyphs, properties or other information for an existing character or characters (including symbols).”
- ☐ All authors and potential IP holders identified in the submission form; applicable CLA(s) in place.
- ☐ No font file submitted unless a later revision actually proposes a representative-glyph change or Unicode requests a font.
- ☐ No third-party manuscript photograph or publisher figure included unless rights are cleared.
- ☐ Historical claims remain carefully qualified; constructed examples are not presented as corpus evidence.
- ☐ Routing request identifies the CJK & Unihan Working Group / UTC because the matter is CJK-related and concerns an existing character.

References

- [1] Unicode Consortium. “CJK Symbols and Punctuation: U+303B VERTICAL IDEOGRAPHIC ITERATION MARK.” Unicode NamesList. https://www.unicode.org/charts/nameslist/n_3000.html
- [2] Unicode Consortium. “Ideographic Symbols and Punctuation: U+16FE3 OLD CHINESE ITERATION MARK.” Unicode NamesList. https://www.unicode.org/charts/nameslist/n_16FE0.html
- [3] West, Andrew, and Eiso Chan. 2017. “Proposal to Encode Two Marks for Ancient Chinese Texts.” ISO/IEC JTC1/SC2/WG2 N4847; Unicode L2/17-310. <https://www.unicode.org/wg2/docs/n4847-TwoMarksAncientChinese.pdf>
- [4] Unicode Consortium. “Unicode Character Encoding Stability Policies.” Updated 26 May 2026. https://www.unicode.org/policies/stability_policy.html
- [5] Unicode Consortium. UAX #50 / Vertical Orientation data; U+303B treated upright. <https://www.unicode.org/reports/tr50/> and related VerticalOrientation data.
- [6] Unicode Consortium. UAX #14, Unicode Line Breaking Algorithm. U+303B listed among NS (Nonstarter) characters. <https://www.unicode.org/reports/tr14/>
- [7] Unicode Script Encoding Working Group. “Submission Guidelines and Process.” Character-versus-glyph distinction; proposal content and legal requirements. <https://sew.unicode.org/guidelines>
- [8] Unicode Consortium. “Font Submission Policy.” https://www.unicode.org/policies/font_policy.html
- [9] Galambos, Imre. 2010. “Scribal Notation in Medieval Chinese Manuscripts: The hewen (Ligature) and the chongwen (Duplication) Marks.” Manuscript Cultures in Asia and Africa 2: 5-9. University of Hamburg. <https://www.csmc.uni-hamburg.de/publications/mc/files/articles/mc02-galambos.pdf>
- [10] Galambos, Imre. 2014. “Punctuation Marks in Medieval Chinese Manuscripts.” In Manuscript Cultures: Mapping the Field, edited by Jörg Quenzer, Dmitry Bondarev, and Jan-Ulrich Sobisch, 341-358. De Gruyter. <https://doi.org/10.1515/9783110225631.341>
- [11] Unicode Consortium. “Intellectual Property, Licensing & Technical Contribution Policies.” https://www.unicode.org/policies/licensing_policy.html
- [12] Unicode Consortium. “UTC CJK & Unihan Working Group” and “Submitting Proposals.” <https://www.unicode.org/consortium/cjkunihan.html> ; <https://www.unicode.org/pending/docssubmit.html>
- [13] Robinson College, University of Cambridge. “Professor Imre Galambos.” Academic profile and research interests. <https://www.robinson.cam.ac.uk/people/professor-imre-galambos>

Appendix A. Submission-form mapping

Form / procedural item	Draft answer
What is the purpose of this submission?	Change to glyphs, properties or other information for an existing character or characters (including symbols).
Existing character	U+303B 𐤧 VERTICAL IDEOGRAPHIC ITERATION MARK.
New script?	No.
New character(s)?	No.
New symbol(s)?	No.
New emoji/flag?	No.
What is being changed?	Primary request is review of additional contextual usage and “other information” ; no normative property change and no representative-glyph replacement requested at this stage.

Form / procedural item	Draft answer
Proposed glyph material	Figure 1 is an illustrative glyphic/calligraphic variant only; it is not a separate encoded character.
Working-group routing requested	CJK & UniHan Working Group / UTC.
ISO/IEC 10646 Proposal Summary Form	Not applicable to this draft because no character addition to the repertoire is requested. If Unicode staff instruct otherwise, follow that instruction.
Font file	Not submitted because this draft does not request a Unicode code-chart glyph replacement. If later requested, comply with Font Submission Policy.
Authors	Scottilynn Blank, unless additional authors explicitly agree to join.
Potential IP holders	See Section 11 and declare all applicable parties in the submission form.
CLA	Submitter and any actual authors must have the applicable Unicode CLA in place as required by the chosen submission route.

Appendix B. Candidate future annotation wording

The following wording is included only to make the eventual documentation question concrete. It is not requested as an immediate normative change and should not be adopted without stronger independent usage evidence:

303B 𠄎 VERTICAL IDEOGRAPHIC ITERATION MARK

- may also be used in some documented conventions as a contextual omission or abbreviation marker after a shortened Han-character expression

Because the Unicode character name is stable, any future broadening of documented usage should be expressed through an annotation or descriptive text rather than renaming the character. [4] The CJK & UniHan Working Group is specifically asked to advise whether such an annotation would be desirable, premature, or better handled outside the Unicode Standard.

End of proposal

The submitter welcomes technical correction and is prepared to revise the proposal in response to CJK & UniHan Working Group guidance, particularly regarding character identity, historical framing, evidence requirements, and the most appropriate division of responsibility between Unicode and language-standardization bodies.